Westvale Public School
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School Council Meeting minutes
November 20, 2024, 6:30pm

Welcome to those attending –

Name	Present	Name	Present
Mary Sue Meredith	X	Tamara DeCraemer	X
Elysia Cloet	X	Jon Mendoza	X
Tonya Seip	X	Melissa Santo	
Eleanor McGrath		Nikolas Knowles	
Christine Glidden	X	Jennifer Benninger	X
Jennifer Thysman	X	Melanie Columbus	X
Kathy Persad		Jonathan Tyler	
Doerte Shulze	X	Kathleen Siegrist	X
Sarah Steinert	X	Sheena Kinghorn	X
Danika Fraser		Shireen Fawad	
Helen Quinton		Ninaa Persad-Mohammed	

Welcome Message – Tonya

Territorial Acknowledgment - Mary Sue

Principal's Report – Mary Sue

- We have two new teachers, who have started: Mr. Atchison is in grade 1A (no relation to Mrs. Atchison who teaches Kindergarten), and Ms. Gondasch is in Grade 1B.
- Our spirit wear sale was successful, with many parents putting aside the shirts and hoodies as surprises for their children (e.g. holiday gifts).
- Progress reports went home on Monday; these go out half-way through the term. Final report cards for term one come out at the end of January. Formal parent-teacher interviews are not being scheduled, but parents are encouraged to reach out to their child's teacher to discuss the progress, if desired. Teachers can be reached by phone (e.g. leaving a voicemail) or by email (https://wsv.wrdsb.ca/about/staff-list/).
- Clothing Swap
    - Teachers organized clothing swap, which happened on Friday
    - We had a great turnout both for donations and for participation (about double the number of participants as last time)
    - Teachers plan to do another one in the spring
- Winter Break Camp

    - There was a School Day notice regarding the availability of a Winter Break camp offered by Extended Day. If you are interested, please refer to the School Day message for information about how to sign up.
- Dismantling Anti-Black Racism
    - A group of 4 Westvale educators are participating this school year in a program called dismantling anti black racism.
    - Educators applied to the program and were accepted, and are learning a lot.
    - They have heard from parents of black students and black educators regarding their experienced racism within the school system.
    - Community organizers also spoke about how to engage with community organizations for support.
- There is continued painting happening around the school; these improvements will continue throughout the year.
- Winter Assembly
    - Will be having a winter assembly and parents are invited to attend.
    - This year, we are planning to do it differently because the gym was over the capacity last year. Extra chairs have also been ordered.
    - One assembly will be students only (where students both perform and sit in the audience)
    - A second performance will also be scheduled where only parents are in the audience
- Save the Date! Assembly is December 18th at 11:50 am.

Teacher's Report- Elysia Cloet

- We had a Remembrance Day assembly, and it was meaningful and beautiful. It was a ceremony and not a performance and was restricted to students and staff. Students were respectful.
- Grade 1 and 2 students went on their trip to Center in the Square, and teachers have extended heartfelt appreciation for the support from council to sponsor this trip.
- Carnivale
    - There is a request from the French teachers for help with hot chocolate for Carnivale, which is a winter-time celebration in Quebec. We have done our own Westvale celebration every year for the past few years. It involves outdoor stations as well as a hot chocolate/apple cider station.
    - Teachers are looking for support with the hot chocolate station (renting the urns for the hot beverages, purchasing the apple cider and hot chocolate mix, purchasing paper cups, preparing the beverages and distributing to children during the event).
    - The event will be hosted on Feb 7th from approximately 11:40-1:40
    - We currently have 1 big hot chocolate (sealed) and a few cups, but will need 1-2 other canisters of hot chocolate and one canister of apple cider
    - Teachers are estimating a cost of approximately $150
    - Jen Benninger motioned for $200 for Carnivale, and Christine seconded. The majority voted in favour and the motion passed.
    - If you can volunteer for this event, please reach out to Jennifer Benninger.
- Orange You Glad You Can Read Day is coming up, where students can wear orange and bring their favourite book

Treasurer's Report – Eleanor McGrath

- There was one new expense: Jeremy and Jazzy Field Trip for $480
- The outstanding commitments have been adjusted (including performances and N4L donations)
- We have $9416.23 in the account. After estimated commitments (and the 3k reserve) we have $883.
- We had $83.12 of revenue from Mabel's Labels and $70 for Herrle's (late cash deposit)
- Expecting revenue from Four All sales to come soon, but those will be donated to Nutrition for Learning

WRAPSC – Jen Benninger

- Jen encourages people to come to WRAPSC to see a lot of varied perspectives
- The next meeting is January 7th and will be discussing the PRO grant
- The last meeting had indigenous equity and human rights departments come to speak, and talked about affinity groups
- They also talked about System Navigators, who help when there is a breakdown in understanding between administrators and families. These are a limited resource and are used as a last resort to mend relationships.
- They also talked about Interpretation and Translation services
    - These services are accessible through the board (via a third party)
    - They allow parents and educators to connect using an interpreter if there is a language barrier. Services are provided through a third party.
    - Teachers can engage to reach out to a parent, or a parent can ask for these services (requests can be made by email).
    - Typically support is by phone, but in-person is also available with longer wait times.
- Trustee came in to speak about the role of a trustee and what they can and cannot do (Madith Radlin spoke)
    - Trustees can advocate for the schools they represent, but they are not involved in hiring the director.
    - A trustee cannot make big decisions on behalf of the school board, their responsibility is to represent the school or send letters to the government.
    - If you have specific concerns about what the trustee can do to provide feedback regarding the director, the WRAPSC chair will collect feedback and forward it on to the trustee (wrapsc@gmail.com)
- The letter that was discussed last time (with regard to reporting certain types of events that happen at schools to parents) will not be sent.
    - They have decided to hold off for now over concerns, many of which we discussed during the last council meeting.
    - Parents were told that if/when a trauma team is called out as the result of an incident that parents will be informed at that time, and that is the existing policy/procedure.

Parents Reaching Out (PRO) Grants - Tonya

- The PRO Grant comes out every year and the goal is to connect and support parents within the school community. https://www.wrdsb.ca/pic/parents-reaching-out-pro-grants/
- This year we have automatically received $500 with no application! (Usually we have to fill out a form, but not this year.)

- There are, however, some limits on what we can spend this on. If it is not spent, it will be reclaimed at the end of the year.
- We have to meet one of the following criteria:
    - Fosters parent engagement
    - Addresses social inclusion and racism
    - Provides translation of posters or literature
    - Demonstrates respect for parents as valued partners in their children's education (e.g. purchasing parenting books for loan)
    - Informs parents about the Ontario curriculum and expectations (e.g. Literacy Night)
- We usually work with the principal to determine what's needed in the school, and we vote on how to use the money.
- This year, it could be about math or literacy (especially looking at some of our EQAO results from last year).
- There was feedback that the Literacy night was really helpful last year, and it might have been even better earlier in the year. The literacy night was organized and run by several teachers to educate parents on how the new Science of Reading approach to literacy is helping students to learn to read and gain fluency.
    - Information can be found here (https://www.wrdsb.ca/learning/programs/structured-literacy-multi-year-plan-slmyp/). We are phasing this in and are currently in year 4.

Four All Ice Cream Update – Tonya

- Four All Ice Cream Sales have begun!
- As a reminder, all money earned will be donated to Nutrition for Learning.
- Christine agreed to help teachers purchase ice cream, if they wish, as teachers do not have access to purchase items on School Day. Christine is to send Mary Sue an email about accepting e-transfers from teachers for ice cream that she can forward.
- Orders due to Four All by December 3rd; Tonya to get the numbers and cheque from Jacquie once the sale period is concluded
- Pick Up will be Monday 16th from 3:30-5:30, and several volunteers have agreed to help with the distribution (thank you in advance to all who are volunteering!).
- We will send a reminder two days before the deadline. Christine will write the post.
- There was concern about how to manage orders that are not picked up. If it's a small number, Mary Sue said there's limited space in the school's chest freezer. For Herrle's it was effective to post on the Westvale Facebook group to remind parents about the pickup. A reminder email on the day of pickup should also be sent.

Movie Night Update – Jennifer and Sheena

- Our movie night is tomorrow! We have some volunteers, and asked for some additional help from those present at the meeting to help make sure parents stay with their children (instead of dropping them off).
- Volunteers will help with setting up the mats on the gym floor (only the red mats can be used, the blue mats are new and will be kept on the walls).
- Volunteers needed to help set up Room 18 with activities for students who need a break from the movie. This room will have colouring supplies as well as the large-scale games that belong to the school.

- Mary Sue and Jen B will set up 3 tables by the gym for popcorn, and we will also set up a donation box to collect voluntary donations for the event
- Some Logistical Notes:
    - It is recommended to pre-package the popcorn in the small bags so several are ready to go, but DO NOT start distributing to students until 5 minutes before the movie starts. This prevents a lot of traffic at the tables from students getting many refills before the movie begins. Two volunteers packing up popcorn would be ideal.
    - Need a "Reverse Bouncer" at the door to make sure any children who enter the school are accompanied by an adult, and that the adult stays. It may be prudent to make a sign.
    - Volunteers in the gym watching the movie are encouraged to remind students of the rules during the movie if they are being loud or disruptive.
    - A donation box should be closed (e.g. a shoe box with a hole cut out).
    - Before the movie begins, an introduction should be given to level set on the rules and expectations for the event
        - Jen B and Mary Sue will present this information
            - Reminder for parents to stay with their students
            - Room 18 is available if students need a break or start getting bored
            - Reminder regarding Four All for ice cream; with proceeds to Nutrition 4 Learning
            - Reminder that there is a donation bucket available, this helps to fund things like school field trips
            - Reminder that it's a movie and those in the gym should be quiet and remain seated
- Jen B picked up 4 big bags of popcorn. It's nut-free, dairy-free, and gluten-free.
- Mary Sue and Jen B will set up the sound right after school and open the wall between the two halves of the gym.

Big Box of Cards – Christine

- Big box of cards is a fundraiser we've run in the past, which we can run online via School Day. There are four different boxes of cards, and we can sell all four at once, with no minimums and free delivery.
- Each box retails for $35 (3 boxes have 35 cards, one box has 50).
- Our profit is $11 per box minus school day fees of 2.9 percent, which we pay on the full sale price of $35 (approximately $1.02 per box). This leaves us with a profit of approximately $9.99/box.
- After some discussion, the consensus was that there was interest in running this fundraiser, but that we will do so in March because Jan/Feb is very busy for Jacquie with report cards, and we need her help to list the products, write the cheque, etc.
- We will pick campaign dates (likely in March) at the January meeting.
- Christine proposed that funds to go for field trips; goal should be to end the year with enough to fund field trips right from the start the way we could this year.

Events to Discuss – Dance, Fun Fair, Science Fair – Jennifer and Sheena

- There is interest in hosting a School Dance or music/movement event. It was suggested that it would be good in Feb around Valentine's, but Mary Sue explained that this is a very busy time

for staff with report cards. Generally we cannot do anything from late January through the end of February because of report card writing.

- Ideas around a February dance included:
    - Could be a theme (formal, wear red, etc.)
    - Could be a fundraiser or suggested donation
- There is interest in running this event, but we would need to find a DJ or determine how to play our own music. Tonya volunteered to DJ using spotify, if allowed. Mary Sue says that if we play music in this way, we cannot run it as a fundraiser.
- If we DJ the event ourselves, it was suggested we could create a Google form, per classroom for music selections
- We could not collect fundraising money on the day of the event, if we DJ it ourselves, but could consider using School Day to allow students to pre-order glow bracelets with pick up on the day of the event
    - It was suggested that we provide the option to order one for someone else on School Day
- Event Date: March 4th, 6:30-8:00
    - Some students can't dance and it's suggested we have another activity and call the event "music and movement"
- Science Fair
    - Ran out of time to discuss, will talk about it at the next meeting
- Book Fair
    - Ran out of time to discuss
    - Book sales will happen April 1 and 2
- Fun Fair – Sheena and Jen B
    - Events team has started calling food trucks;
        - Kono Pizza and Mega Cone who do 10% cash back to school on sales, would like to come for the fun fair
    - There was a suggestion to involve the students in coming up with activities for the fun fair
        - It was suggested that Grade 5s and 6s could to come up with the games and then run them during the fun fair
        - Mary Sue said she can invite the teachers to participate in this initiative, but we need to make sure that it doesn't take up too much class time
    - Raffle Baskets
        - Sometimes the students donate to the raffle basket, and it was suggested we do that again this year
        - There are 18 classrooms. Each classroom could vote from a list of categories provided by council, and they collect items toward that basket theme
        - Jen is looking for help to approach businesses for donations for the raffle baskets as well; if you know someone who might be able to contribute to a raffle basket or are interested in helping to solicit donations, please reach out to Jen Benninger
    - Events and Activities
        - It was suggested we could rent carnival games
        - Another suggestion was to ask the Titans or Rangers if they will come, or rent a hockey shot

        - Activities such as frisbee golf could be a low cost addition, if parents can loan their equipment to the school for the event
        - If you want to contribute ideas, please reach out to Jen or Sheena
        - Cotton Candy is requested again this year along with balloon animals
        - It was suggested we could add carnival style games with small prizes (simple activities were suggested like tossing a bean bag into a hoola hoop, where our cost and complexity to run the event is kept low).
    - We need to solicit via School Day for volunteers

Offer for a speaker – Tonya

- The lawyers (who've volunteered at the school for face painting) are offering to speak about the importance of wills and estate planning. They have offered to come for no-cost.
- One parent raised a concern about the fairness of having this speaker in when there may be parents at the school who also offer this service, as this is an income-generating event.
- In the interest of fairness, it was suggested that we mention the plan to host this event for wills and estate planning and invite any other members of the school community to join this discussion.
- It was also suggested that we ask if anyone else has a business they think would offer beneficial services and if they would like to speak during a council meeting.
- It was suggested that speakers could be on the same day as the council, and that we could perhaps extend the meeting from 6:15-8:15 to accommodate the speaker
- The plan is to write a school day about speakers and to start the January 22nd meeting at 6:15 meeting, ending at 8:15 and to include the estate planning speaker as a part of that.

Fundraising Thoughts - How to Earn and How to Spend – Tonya

- We discussed how much fundraising we should be doing in relation to charitable giving. While we have enough funds to cover our events this year, we need to be aware that to have the same privilege next year, we need to build the account back up again. This would allow us to fund field trips early in the year, the way we did this year.
- One parent is wondering about the possibility of adding the ability to pay for another student on School Day for things like field trips or Pizza Days.
- The WEFI account was mentioned again, with a possibility of sending out an email for giving Tuesday with the WEFI URL.
- Mary Sue is hesitant to run any other fundraisers directly for the school (like a sponsorship) because we just did spirit wear.

Next Meeting Date – January 22nd, 2024 from 6:30-8:00 pm

Future Meeting Dates – January 22, February 19, April 16, May 21, and June 18